



“I came to know about iVolunteer through word of mouth. I am usually free during my weekends, and I thought, why not utilise this time to do something beneficial for society?”

Devang Bhatt
Virtual volunteer for Akshara

have iVolunteer Indian Fellow, iVolunteer Overseas, Employee Volunteering, and National and International Volunteering. Refer box *More About iVolunteer*.

NGOs are realising the importance of the Internet to be able to reach out to people in far-off places (as in funding and mobilising volunteers); they also find it difficult to commit resources to build and manage their Web sites. Sahai, director of iVolunteer India, has this to say: “Virtual volunteers can help NGOs not just technically—like choosing the Web server, scripting language, and database server—but also as advisors on how to gain the most from the Internet.”

Richa Sood, relations executive at iVolunteer tells us, “Resource mobilisation—particularly fund-raising, is a lifeline to almost all non-profits. Often these require no face-to-face interface with the organisation, and campaigns can be carried out using the various mediums that IT offers.”

One needs to remember that the efforts you put in can possibly also help in career growth. Web sites you create for NGOs can be listed on your résumé. In the case of a businessman, the Web site could stand testimony to your organisation’s skills. NGOs are always looking out for people to help spread awareness in regards to relevant issues, and Web sites being the best medium, volunteers for Web site development are the most sought-after.

iVolunteer is seeking people to help with writing and designing reading material. Those with modest skill-sets are placed in back-office work like keeping records of finances and day-to-day activities. People who know more than two languages are placed as translators, who are in great demand by NGOs: as they grow, they require people to localise all the reading material they generate.

And coming to figures, iVolunteer has thus far placed over 5,000 volunteers in various programmes. However, they admit that virtual volunteering is a small part of this figure. Yes, it is just taking off, and again, *you* can help.

On The Other Side

Volunteers working over the Internet have helped Ashoka, which we mentioned earlier, even in areas such as research. Researchers at Ashoka are working on projects as diverse as rain water harvesting and genetically engineered crops. Such research allows both scientist and entrepreneur to attract fresh participants and resources to the long-standing problem of rural development. As an example of how such work affects rural development, research on genetically engineered crops and foods helps in examining their impact on the environment, human and animal health, and traditional agriculture.

Bill Drayton, a social entrepreneur, founded Ashoka in 1980 in Washington DC with an annual budget of \$50,000 (Rs 20 lakh). He elected its first Fellow in India a year later. In its early years, the focus of this NGO was on promoting social entrepreneurs. Now with over 1,800 volunteers from 60 countries rang-

More About iVolunteer

Here are iVolunteer’s programmes besides their online volunteering coordinating efforts:

iVolunteer Indian Fellow

Here, undergraduates spend six weeks living and working with rural NGOs.

iVolunteer Overseas

The volunteer goes to other developing countries for work in the field of child education, housing, and sanitation.

Employee Volunteering

Employees of corporate organisations work with local communities to contribute towards the community and environment.

National And International Volunteering

This is for individuals, both Indian and foreign, contributing to social causes in India.

ing from businessmen, journalists, investors, and academics, Ashoka is helping out in a wide range of programmes and initiatives that deal with the basic necessities like food and water around the world.

Ashoka has various other virtual volunteering opportunities. They need people to promote funding, strategic planning, marketing, designing of their Web site, and translation. Opportunities can be found listed in the Ashoka Volunteer bimonthly newsletter. You can sign up for the newsletter by writing to volunteers@ashoka.org with “Newsletter” in the subject line. It carries information about whom to directly contact if one wishes to help.

One must never forget that motivation is an important aspect for a volunteer working at home or office. Of course, this is important anyway, but is especially so for a virtual volunteer: it’s easier to fall asleep at your chair than on the field! In addition, volunteers can tend to feel isolated and undervalued, and over time, decide to leave a project halfway. It is important that a volunteer be willing to take ownership over the experience.

If You Have A Heart And The Time...

Before embarking on any virtual volunteering project, you need to remember—once again, it must be repeated—that virtual volunteering begins with a strong belief in the cause, so be sure it’s something you want to, and can, commit to. You can also make your contribution to a cause over the phone or via fax if you don’t have access to the Internet.

With over a billion Internet users in the world, even if a tiny fraction take up this route of helping out, there can be a huge impact. We won’t end on a weepy note... but we’ve told you what’s possible. It’s up to you—remember, you needn’t set foot in uncharted, unmapped territory, weather boots and all! ■

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